

SIR OTONDE MICHAEL -DELEGATE



KENYATTA UNIVERSITY

INSTITUTE OF OPEN & VIRTUAL LEARNING

DEPARTMENT OF RELIGIOUS STUDIES

ARE 270: INTRODUCTION TO CHURCH HISTORY

BY KELVIN EKALIYO, THE NEXT.

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COURSE DESCRIPTION

The major historical settings; Early Church up to East west Schism in 1054AD; Medieval Church 1054-1500 and the Modern Church from 18th to the 19th Century; Modern trends in Christianity, Missionary expansion in the world.

COURSE OUTLINE

PART ONE; THE EARLY CHURCH (1st -12th Century

1. Immediate background and environment
2. The Christ Event
3. Apostolic and Post-apostolic Church
4. Persecution of the Church
5. Emperor Constantine the Great and his influence on the Church
6. Monasticism and its effect on the growth of the Church
7. The Early Church Fathers
8. Heresies and the Early Church Councils
9. The Great Schism-East and West
10. The Church in North Africa

PART TWO: MEDIEVAL CHURCH (13th -18th Century

11. The Crusades
12. The inquisition

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13. The Papacy

14. The Reformation and its effects (Martin Luther and the reasons for the split, new

And various denominations and their founders –Calvin, Zwingli, Wycliff, etc).

PART THREE: THE CHURCH IN THE MODERN AGE (19th Century)

15. Modern trends in Christianity-pietism, Methodism, Revivalism, Humanism, Rationalism etc.

16. Modern Missionary Movement; modern Christian movements; Revival movements; Pentecostals and independent Churches.

17. The Ecumenical Movement

18. African Institute Churches

19. Inculturation

READING LIST

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Atkinson, Martin Luther and the Birth of Protestantism Scott Press, 1982.

Bookman Norbert; 2004; History of the Catholic Church, Paulines, Nairobi.

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NB: Read any available books on Church History.

INTRODUCTION TO CHURCH HISTORY

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LESSON ONE 1.0 BACKGROUND AND ENVIRONMENT

Christianity is essentially a Historical Religion. A historical fact about Jesus, his followers, the church, events etc. Church history is thus the history of Christianity from its beginning to the present.

-Christianity was however influenced by certain historical facts that preceded the Christian era. (AD4)

Examples -;

(a) Judaism; Christianity is an outgrowth of the religion of the Jews. The Jews were politically never important except during the time of David and Solomon (900-1000BC) **But they were regarded as the chosen people.**

Chosen people-: They believed that they were the chosen people from the time of Abraham. That God had chosen them for a purpose –task after the fall of Adam and Eve .They also believed that success or failure depended on their loyalty to Yahweh their God.-Salvation History.

(b) Torah

The Jewish way of life of was guided by the Torah plus other laws and regulations. The cone of their faith was the chief commandment that God is one and must be loved and obeyed always.

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(c) **Exodus** -: The destruction of Egypt and the crossing of the Red sea are among the greatest events in the Jewish history .This was part of the gradual revelation of Yahweh's mission of salvation or redemption.

(d) **Prophets**, Kings, Judges and Priests were from time to time appointed to guide the people of Israel.

They constantly denounced disobedience, sin and oppression. They reminded the people that God chose them so that through them salvation could come to all Nations-hence there was a purpose- ie salvation History.

(e) **Messianic hope**

Thus they hoped for a future leader, saviour and redeemer Messiahs.

-They believed that the Messiah would come from among them to establish in Israel the kingdom of God .Thus raising Israel above all Nations and that he would rule all Nations and for ever with mighty and power

-This conviction kept them going or was a great source of inspiration to them.

- After they were scattered in various parts of Mediterranean world (from time to time of the Northern and the southern kingdom) the Jews were strongly united by their monotheistic Religion –Judaism and the messianic hope.

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-Until after the destruction of Jerusalem during **Neronian persecution** (64 AD) **Jerusalem** was the center of Judaism and wherever they went the Jews established centres of worship and teaching called **Synagogues**. Various Religious groups were also founded.

Religious Groups

1. Scribes:

These were professional teachers and scholars of the Jewish law both written and its oral tradition.

- It is in the synagogues that the scribes could teach and expound on the law and the prophets to the people of Israel.
- They were very respected people and were seen as Holy.

2. Sadducees

- These emerged before the birth of Jesus Christ.
- This group strictly observed the Torah word by word.
- Initially they were called Hassidians but they later acquired the name Sadducees in the New Testament

3. Pharisees

The Pharisees saw themselves as the representatives of the **Orthodox Judaism**.

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- Like the Sadducees they also took the Torah very seriously
- They laid down the line of conduct to be followed by the Jewish communication.
- They regarded themselves as the role models. They took the first places in the synagogues; The Rabbi class belonged to this group

4. Essenes

Fidelity of the law and zeal for its fulfillment drove another group of Jews called Essenes out of public life, into the wilderness.

- This group later came to be known as the Qumuran Community.
- The community believed that the ordinary Jews had been corrupted by sin. (that Satan had populated the synagogues-temples). Thus the entire Jewish community required purification according to the Essenes. -The Qumuran regarded themselves as the remnant of the Jewish community .They lived a Monastic life and emphasized on God's love.

Apocalyptic literature

This literature flourished in the Qumuran community. The apocalypse means to uncover or reveal. This according to the community was divine revelation of the community was divine revelation of the future. The literature mainly focused on the Eschatology or the last things including death; final victory over evil, last judgment and resurrection of the humanity. Books such as Esdras, Ecclesiasticus, Maccabees 1 & 2 Esther,

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Judith ,Tobit ,Book of Jubilee, Book of Enoch etc are associated with this community. Some books may not have been canonized.

The Jews in Diaspora-Diaspora Jews

Either willingly or by force the Jews had spread and scattered in various parts of the Mediterranean religion outside Palestine e.g. in Rome, Antioch, Alexandria etc

-These Diaspora Jews lived in organized congregations. They had synagogue in which they met for prayer. They were held together by the Jewish religion

-They however abandoned their mother tongue, Hebrew and adopted the Greek language.

-The Diaspora Jews used the Septuagint the Greek Translation of the Bible also known as LXX or the Alexandrian text. This was the only accepted translation of the Bible by the time of Christ and much later .These Diaspora Jews were to assist (in missionary work or) in the spread of the movement of Jesus-Christianity.

LESSON TWO

ROMAN WORLD DURING THE BIRTH OF JESUS CHRIST

(1.) During the inception of Christianity the Roman Empire occupied nearly the Whole of the Mediterranean Basin.

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To the North the empire extended to River(s), Rhine, (France), while to the south The Sahara desert was the limit. To the west the boundary was the Atlantic Ocean

and to the East it bounded Persia running through Asia

(2.) The Roman Empire had Emperors \ commanders (in-Chief) who ruled through a well organized and efficient system

(3.) The people enjoyed the benefits of the Roman rule, peace and civilization referred to as Pax-Romana or Roman peace.

(4) Trade and agriculture flourished and so did **literature and art**. Laws were made and **justice was administered**.

5 -Many roads were constructed for the passage of armies and trade – Thus Communication by road was very cheap.

(6). Communication by seas was also possible . Ships crossed the Mediterranean sea from one point to the other .There were no borders, no traveling and hence no migration restrictions.

7. -There were (safe) cheap and very efficient Postal services between different towns. Thus news traveled quickly as the

Romans were literate and also keen letter writers. These letters were often read

aloud to the people but some were also private –Paul's letters

(7) **Latin was the official language** while Greek was the common language in the Roman Empire.

(8). However the Roman Religion was indeed polytheistic with a collecting of gods from Italy, Greek, &Egypt & Asia.

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-Temples of worship were centres of **drunkenness and prostitution**.

(9) There was then the Jewish religion with its long history of salvation and the Torah plus other laws that governed (social) behaviors.

(10) Politically the Roman emperors were very cruel. Crucifixion was only one of the many methods of torture and execution to which people were condemned for Light offences.

-in summary this was the situation in which Christ lives, taught and died and consequently the world in which Christianity or the church was founded.

NB Roman Empire included the present Portugal, Spain, France, Italy, Yugoslavia, Greece, Roman, Bulgaria, Hungary, Austria, Turkey, Northern Africa, Syria, Iraq, Iran, Jordan and some part of Saudi Arabia

-Religions of these regions were:- polytheistic eg Zoroastrianism (Persia) Hinduism -----Buddhism far East & Jewish Religion monotheistic.

2.0 THE CHRIST'S EVENT (N.T CHURCH)

The story about the founder of Christianity could be traced back to the Old Testament prophets such as Isaiah and Jeremiah foretold the coming of the Messiah who would redeem mankind. This was fulfilled in Jesus Christ.

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The Christian Church is named after the founders Jesus of Nazareth also known as Christ meaning the anointed one. This man was born in Bethlehem in Judea around 4BC. He grew up (unnoticed) in the home of a Jewish carpenter named Joseph, a descendant of King David.

At around age 30 he was baptized in River Jordan by a man named John the Baptist. Although he lived for about 33 years, he taught for less than three years. His ministry is presented in the Gospels. Very little is known about the historical Christ, the writers of the gospel were truly convinced that Jesus truly lived in history and died a terrible death through crucifixion. -The followers of Jesus were named Christians from his title which means the anointed.

-Jesus was a Jew who spoke Aramaic the popular dialect of the Hebrews.

He began his ministry with twelve Apostles with whom he went to the country side preaching and teaching, healing the sick and feeding the poor

- In his message (mission) he announced the coming of Gods kingdom. He declared the need for repentance of sin and acceptance of the good News
- His message did not please the Roman authorities and so.
- At age 33 he was arrested, tortured and put to death by the Roman authorities in collaboration with some Jews. This was probably around AD30 He was buried but resurrected three days later, he then departed

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from the world leaving behind a small Christian community of the Disciples –followers. The Apostles then took over the mission of spreading the god News about the kingdom of God.

- The initial centre of Christianity was in Jerusalem also the centre of Judism. It was here that Jesus was crucified and died but also resurrected. The Pentecost experience a lot took place in Jerusalem
- After this experience Peter became the spokesman of the Christianity.
- This community continued to use the temple of Jerusalem as a place of worship. Christianity thus appeared like another sect of Judaism.
- soon Christianity spread to the whole Mediterranean world and later that the followers of Christ were first nicknamed Christianity by Paul of Tarsus.

Jesus of Nazareth

-As a Jew his followers worshipped the God of his fathers –They prayed in

private, attended synagogues every Sabbath paid tax to support the

temple in Jerusalem, participated in festivals in the temples

-His message as on the kingdom of God-spiritual kingdom to some others it meant the end of the world.

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-His preaching \message \teaching was in stories \parables- short –His message was how life should be lived

-He urged his listeners to be loving, imitating God's love.

-A small group of men and some woman followed Him –Among the group were 12 Apostles

-One of his followers betrayed Him & the authorities (police) although he was a liberation theologian who believed In a completely new government\leadership –with God at the top.

- He was said to have lead small demonstration in Jerusalem organized his followers against evil activities .This was during the Passover festival around AD30 to commemorate the Jewish liberation from Egypt .He was arrested and accused of causing disturbances and for not paying due respect to the Roman authorities. He did not defend himself aft all. Consequently he was crucified along with two criminals (dangerous) -Crucification was a public slow &fatal torture and was a ay of punishing notorious criminals.

-After his death the moment of Christians were led by twelve men called Apostolic meaning envoys. They represented the12 tribes of Israel.

-Most Jews did not accept the Christian moment (Jesus moment)but the few who believed him founded a small family \community.

LESSON THREE THE APOSTOLIC AND POST APOSTOLIC PERIOD

On the day of Pentecost Peter preached in Jerusalem and about **three thousand people were baptized**. The apostles spoke in tongues they also acquired **new understanding of their mission** which was a unique

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inspirations. After this Pentecost experience the Apostles (Peter and John mark) performed **healing miracles**. This increased the no of followers to about 5,000 (Acts 3-4;4)

The growing Christianity community **greatly disturbed the Jewish authorities** who sent for the Apostles for examination (scrutiny) Peter was their spokesman .Here too they **preached with authority** about the risen Lord. **More miracles were performed** and the no of followers increased considerably. Consequently the apostles were **persecuted**. They however insisted that God must be obeyed rather than man (Acts 5; 29)

The early Christian community did not appear very different from the Jewish community.

- a) They **kept the Jewish law** and joined daily in **the temple** of worship .
- b) They were more or less like the **Jews synagogue**, a Greek word meaning meeting

Nevertheless they (church) differed from the ordinary Jew in three ways.

- (a) The Jews still waited for the **Messiah** while the Christians believed that He had already come died and rose from the dead.
- (b) While **circumcision** was assign for the chosen people-Jews – Christians believed that **baptism** was the entry point.
- (c) Lastly the Christians **broke the bread** during Sabbath day to commemorate the Lords supper. The Jews had the **Passover meal instead**.

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-The apostles \disciples at first thought that the **second coming** was too soon. Therefore, Many of them left their ordinary occupations and became **full time preachers**.

-Among them was Stephen who seemed to be a very effective preacher. He was **condemned to death** by the Jews way of stoning for blasphemy. This opened the gate for **martyrdom** in which Saul of Tarsus (Paul) who was a Rabbi (teacher of the law) took the lead to persecute Christians.

SAUL OF TARSUS-Who was Paul?

Saul late named Paul was a **Diaspora Jew** from the tribe of Benjamin .His birth place was Tarsus in Cilicia, Asia minor (Turkey). He was a **Roman citizen** .He was **educated in Jerusalem under a Pharisee named Gamaliel**. He was a trusted argent of the **Sanhedrin**.

The word Sanhedrin comes from the **Greek term sunedrion** (literally, "sitting together") **meaning council**. The Sanhedrin is both **a Jewish judicial and administrative body**. The Sanhedrin was composed of local elites--including members of the high-priestly family, scribes (religious experts), and lay elders.

It is in Jerusalem that Saul came into conduct with the followers of Christ and participated in the Stephen's Martyrdom. Paul was sent to Damascus

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with letters from the high priest to arrest and bring to Jerusalem all the followers of the Nazarene heresy late named Christians.

But on his way to Damascus Paul had a miraculous encounter with Jesus, the risen Lord and he was converted. He was then baptized by Ananias as Paul and for three years he had to hide in Arabia to escape Jewish persecution.

Together with other Apostles Paul founded the first Christian community at Antioch in Syria and later founded other communities eg Iconium , Lystra and Lyconia (Asia minor) Paul addressed himself to both the Diaspora Jews and pagans meaning people of the country side.

In AD 49 the council of Jerusalem was called during which Paul declared that man is not justified by the works of the law but by faith in Jesus Christ. (Gal 2:16) Thus it was categorically declared in the council of Jerusalem that gentiles did not require circumcision in order to become Christians.

Between AD 51-64 Paul took his second journey with Silas and Timothy. They visited the congregations in Cilicia and Lyconia and established others in Philippi, Thessalonica, Corinth and Ephesus.

Paul wrote many letters both to communities and to individuals such as Philippians, Thessalonians, Corinthians, Ephesians etc. While in Rome as a captive Paul wrote what is referred to as captivity letters (Philippians ,Ephesians ,Colossians and Philemon).

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Approximately one third of the New Testament consists of letters, or epistles, whose authorship is associated with Paul the Apostle. Such letters were addressed to the Christian churches of his day and the issues that affected them. Because these letters are much older than any of the gospel accounts of the life of Jesus, they constitute the most reliable source that we have today for information concerning the early history of the Christian movement. With few exceptions, these letters were written in response to conditions that existed in the particular churches with which Paul was associated.

Sometimes later after Paul's death these letters were circulated among the churches and read along with the Old Testament Scriptures as a part of regular worship services. Still later, they came to be regarded as inspired writings comparable to the sacred Scriptures of Judaism.

Paul was imprisoned twice in Rome. It was during the second imprisonment in AD 64 in Rome that Paul and Peter were martyred in what is referred to as the Neronian persecution. Paul was only the highest teaching authority, but also the chief Judge. Appointed to assist him were the presbyters or elders whom Paul ordained during his journeys. These leaders were to guide the local communities. However these Pauline communities were not seen as distinct congregations. Rather they were (a Church or) a community of believers guided by the risen `Lord. (The Christian church had started \began.`

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LESSON FOUR

THE CHURCH IN AFRICA

(A) Egypt

The city of Alexandria was established by **Alexander** the great of Greece, who concurred Egypt around BC 332. (Much later Egypt fell under the Romans). At the time of Christ Egypt was part of the Romans Empire from the **3rd century AD**. Egypt was predominantly a Christian land until the Muslim Arab conquest in AD 641-642. (7th century)

- Egypt was evangelized by St Mark who may have gone to Alexandria from Cyprus (Acts 16:36-39)
- Mark is said to have been the first Bishop of Alexandria, other leaders of the Egyptian Church included Clement, Cyprian Origen, Antony, Pachomius, Athanasius and Cyril among others
- The church in the Egypt was famous for its **catechetical school**. (Alexandrian School of theology and Philosophy) which came to influence the church for a very long time.
- The Coptic Church continues to the present day inspite of Muslims influence in Egypt.
- **Alexandria** became one of the four centers of Christianity, the others were **Jerusalem, Antioch** and Rome
- It was in Alexandria that the **Septuagint** (Jerusalem Bible was translated). This was the Greek version of the Hebrew Bible (or Old

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Testament), including the Apocrypha, made for Greek-speaking Jews in Egypt and adopted by the early Christian Churches

(B) **Ethiopia**

Christianity was taken to Ethiopia by Frumentius and Edesius probably around AD 333 after Fraumentius became the Bishop of Ethiopia Who converted the Ethiopian King, Ezna. Ezna made Christianity the official religion of the religion.

- Between AD 650-1268 the church in Ethiopia struggled with the rise of Islam. Many wars were fought in this period between Christians and Pagans and between Christians and Muslims. By this time the Church still depended on Alexandria in many ways.
- By the time **Explorers** arrived in Ethiopia in 16th century, majority of the Ethiopians had turned Muslim. Nevertheless the Ethiopian church continued to exist (amongst an Islamic country)
- In AD 1614, the Ethiopian Emperor became a Roman Catholic and in AD 1626 Christianity once again became the official religion of the country.
- In AD1634 Protestantism was introduced in Ethiopia by a German named Peter Heyling. He translated the Gospel of John into Amharic (Ethiopian language) however he was killed in AD1652 by a Muslim fanatic.

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- Between AD 1853 and 1846, groups of **Italians entered Ethiopia and by AD 1853 there were 5,000 Catholics** in the country.
- The Italian Government seemed to have interest in Ethiopia.
- 1896 the Italians acquired a port on the Red sea.

The territory occupied by the Italians was named (Eritrea)

-In 1896 the Italians attempted to invade Ethiopia but were defeated. -In 1935 the **Ethiopian church suffered martyrdom** in the hands of Italian soldiers in an attempt to colonize Ethiopia.

-Ethiopia gained independence in 1945 when the Italians were completely defeated by the British (**Emperor Hailie Selassie** returned to the throne)

-Ever since the **Ethiopian Orthodox Church** was taken by the state. It has a great control over budgets, appointments etc.

Characteristics of the Ethiopian orthodox church

1. Its Canon of scripture has 81 books including the Apocrypha.
2. Sabbath is observed and so are circumcision rituals
3. The issue of clean and unclean meat is taken seriously.
4. The Ark is to be found in every church and at every outdoor festival.
5. Its theology insists that Christ was both divine and perfect human.

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6. It has both trained clergy and preachers- many of them in both cases are **illiterate**.

7. Until about 1900 church schools were the sources of education in Ethiopia.

8. Monasticism has been widely practiced.

9. In 1960 Emperor Haile Selassie authorized the **transition** of the scripture into Amharic later bible commentaries were produced in which protestant missionaries

Played a (great) big role.

10. Nearly 1\2 of the Ethiopians (24 million) people belong to the Ethiopian Orthodox Church.

11. By 1978 religious adherence was as follows-:

Ethiopia Orthodox Church 46%

Muslims 35%

African tradition religion 14%

Protestants 4%

Roman Catholics 0.6%

Jews 0.1%

12. Between 1950-1975 much work was done in Ethiopia by foreign Missionaries. However due to the Marxist system many missionaries left Ethiopia.

13. Consequently some churches have been closed and some church project taken by The Govt.

-However the Protestants congregations have been on the increase considerably.

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-Bible translation into Ethiopian languages have been completed
.Hence there are
Signs of growth.

6.0 MONASTICISM & ITS EFFECTS ON THE CHURCH

Ascetic life started in the time of Constantine however it was not a product of Christianity alone. It was also founding the religion of India Jesus Greeks and Egyptians
Then how did it become a Christian practice?

-with Christianity becoming the state Religion (Roman Religion) in the reign of Constantine, church membership increased considerably.

Among the (new) members were Christians who had betrayed the church, either by sacrificing to idols, buying sacrifices, running away or ley giving up scripture for Destruction.

Following these conditions some of the Christian who had survived the Roman persecution felt the need for a more personal commitment to God. This conviction led to monastic life.

Some Christians fled to the desert where they lived in seclusion in what was reformed to as Monastic life: and where known as monks

Who were the monks?

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Christians Monasticism started in Egypt by Monks .These were people who lived entire alone or in seclusion for prayers. They lived in the desert in small Christian communities.

(1)The Monks left worldly life and lived in seclusion in the desert, caves.

(2)Sometimes they lived in small communities

(11) Their major duties were prayers &worship, Bible reading, cared for the poor and the sick.

Among the outstanding monks were St Anthony, Pachomius, Basil, Athanasius, Benedict, Jerome, Chrysostom etc

-These men gave their possessions and took up ascetic life in the desert. - They believed that the world was evil and so was the body because the devil was after them. Some of those who had betrayed the church were seen as devils

(8)Some monks e.g. St. Antony lived alone white others e.g. Jesome and Chrysostom lived in communities or monasteries.

-They practiced strict self denial i.e. without families and without property (personal)

- They prayed all the time, lived in caves, slept on hard ground and for a short time and ate very little.

-Some of them were great scholars e.g St. Jesome who translated the O.T from Hebrew to Latin and the MT from Greek to Latin. Its from this transit that others have been produced.

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-Some e.g. Chrysostom participated in ordinary life. Some begged for food while others did some work. e.g carpentry, tent making, black-smithing weaving: book making, leather work etc.

However their major duties were prayer, worship, Bible reading ,care for the sick and the poor.

-From Egypt Monasticism spread to France, Rome, Germany and Ireland.

Slowly by slowly monasticism started to influence the church.

-e.g Chrysostom placed Christmas say on 25th December from 6th January.

-He did this because the feast of the sun god, Mithras which was celebrated all over the Roman world on December 25th attracted many Christians.

-So by fixing the birth of Christ on 25th December the celebrating of Mithra was displaced by the feast of Christ.

-The monks were also archeologists. Some of them were very good theologians too, an elit group –who came to influence the thinking of the church.

-These are the people who defended the church from heretics.

-They participated in doctrinal controversies that led to the great church councils.

They also participated in the formulation of Greeds. These monks influenced the early church Fathers.

Antony (AD251-356)

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-The word monk comes from the Greek 'Monachos' meaning one who lives alone. The first monks did actually that –They sold what they had left for seclusion in the desert and devotion to God.

The greatest of these solitary or anchorite monks was Antony who was born in Ethiopia.

-Anchorite comes from a Greek word Anachorein meaning to take to the bush.

-after the death of his parents Antony gave his property to the poor and took off to the desert where he lived as a hermit.

-In the desert Antony fasted, prayed and ate only bread, salt and water.

-He was not educated and spoke Greek

His life came to be admired by others who later followed him to the desert. In protest against the low moral standard and spiritual rite of the church individual Anchorite monks often went to extremes in search for spiritual perfection.

Pachomius (287-346)

-Pachomius introduced community monasticism near River Nile, where he brought together 1300 monks when he died in AD346, there were

about a monasteries and two nunneries for Egypt

-Each monastery was self contained producing food for their use. They farming, kitchen work basket making, cared for the sick etc-the needs of the community were met.

-conditions of entry included:

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1. Ability to read and write in Coptic.
2. Ability to memories certain prayers, psalms & scriptures passages 3. Sacrifices (give up)of wealth to show that he trusted God for everything.
4. Patience & preference

Basil the great

-He was one of the great cappadocian Fathers.

Born of the Christian parents, Basil was educated at Constantinople and at Athens.

-After his education in 356 he was persuaded by his relatives to join monasticism.

He visited monasteries in Egypt, Palestine, Syria and Mesopotamia and started his own communities.

-His communities were small of about 40 members;

-They continued the practice of poverty, charity, obedience prayers and work.

-However he believed that the monastery should be under the control of the church.

That it should not exist for its self but should serve the community outside.

-That Basils monks taught in schools, ran hospitals and home for lepers and the poor.

Basil later became a bishop- Today all eastern orthodox churches insisted that all bishops must be first monks.

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ST . ANTONY (AD 251-356)

St. Antony was born in Egypt in AD 281 .He was one of the greatest monks in history of Christianity.

-The word monk comes from the Greek word Monachos meaning one who lives alone. St. Antony did exactly that.

-After the death of his parents Antony gave his prosperity to the poor and became an anchorite a Greek word meaning to take to the bush\desert.

-In the desert Antony lived alone, fasted, prayed and ate very little. -He was not educated and only spoke Coptic although he knew some Greek.

-His life came to be admired by others who later followed him to the desert.

-He died in AD356 having taught others the extreme way of searching for spiritual perfection.

PACHOMIUS (AD 287-346)

Pachomius introduced community monasticism near River Nile where he brought together 1300 monks. When he died in AD 346. There were about 9 Monasteries and two nunneries –for women in Egypt.

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Each monastery was self contained: The Members did farming, kitchen work, basket making, cared for the poor, sick etc. -The conditions for the entry included;-

- Ability to read and write in Coptic

- Ability to memorize certain prayers, psalms and scripture passages

- Sacrifice of wealth to show that they trusted God for everything.

BASIL THE GREAT (329-379)

He was one of the great Cappadocian Fathers. Born of Christian parents, Basil was educated at Constantinople and later at Athens.

- After his education in 356 he was persuaded by his relatives to join monasticism.

- He visited Monasteries in Egypt, Palestine, Syria and Mesopotamia and started his own communities.

- His communities were small of about 40 members. They practiced poverty, Charity and obedience. They prayed and did work. However -Basil believed that the Monastery should be under the control of the church.

- That it should serve the community outside, Thus

- Basil monks taught in schools, ran hospitals and homes for lepers and the poor. Basil later became a Bishop.

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Today all eastern orthodox church insist that all Bishops must first be monks.

JEROME (345-419)

Jerome was born in Italy and studied in Rome and later in Antioch and Constantinople where he learned Greek and Hebrew.

-He joined a group of ascetics in Rome.

-He condemned the low morals standards in the church.

-In 386 he left Rome and went to Bethlehem where he started a monastery.

-Assisted by a rich woman named Paula Jerome built a monastery and also a nunnery.

-A great scholar ,Jerome revised the old Latin version of the Bible His version was called the vulgate: the Bible of the people.

BENEDICT OF NURSIA (480-547)

Benedict of Nusea was born in Italy and studied in Rome where he was shocked by the evil life he experienced while there. He moves to the desert where he lived in caves.

-Later in AD 529 he moved to Monte casino, between Rome and Naples, where he established a monastery.

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-The Benedictine order grew to become the greatest in the medieval period
St Benedict is remembered for his 73 rules he established for his order.

-The rules guided the society on how and when to pray call meetings, work,
organize and manage monastic life etc

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NON MONASTIC FATHERS

JUSTINE THE MARTYR(AD100-165)

- He was born in Samaria by pagan parents of Greek origin
 - He was converted to Christianity in AD 132.he taught in many places including Rome.
 - He later became an Apologist .He wrote two apologies in defence of the church
 - The first one was addressed to Emperor Antonius Pius in which he demanded that Christianity be accorded freedom of worship and association
 - The second was addressed to Typho, a learned Jew whom he tried to convince about the truth of Christianity.
- He argued that the early philosophies were inspired by the divine logos e.g. Socrates (before Christ)
- He emphasized that salvation comes through death and Resurrection (future event)
- He argued that Christ and the Holy spirit were lower than the Father in the Trinity.
- He as Martyred in Rome in AD165

CYPRIAN OF CARTHAGE (200-258)

His parents were pagans, he was born in Carthage, North Africa in about AD200.He was probably a lawyer.

He was converted about 246 and was ordained a presbyter in 248

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-He was elected Bishop of Carthage soon afterwards

-During the great persecution of the church he went into hiding and tried to run the diocese by writing letters.

-He dealt with three serious problems

1. What the church was to do with the lapsed Christians? Those who had compromised during the persecution either by worshipping idols or obtaining a certificate of worship. Cyprian concluded that only Bishops had the power to forgive those winners who have lapsed.

2. The question of the Novatian schism at Rome, This split had been formed by Novatian around 251AD. The members condemned all those who had betrayed the church and denied them forgiveness.

-Cyprian condemned them and defended the authority of the Bishops and the church.

3. The question of Baptism by Novatists..Cyprian declared invalid all the sacraments administered by the schismatic groups especially baptism

-His view was opposed by Stephen the Bishop of Rome who declared that only baptism done in water in the name of the Holy Trinity was valid irrespective of the celebrant.

-Stephen's view was adopted in the council of Arles which met in France in AD314. Accepted the Roman Catholic Church, most churches follow this view.

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Stephen was martyred in 251 and Cyprian followed him to martyrdom in

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IRENAEUS

He was probably a native of Smyrna in Asia Minor.

He was influenced by Polycarp .He studied in Rome and participated in solving church related disputes.

-He prevented the Bishop of Rome, Victor from excommunicating the church of Asia Minor for celebrating Easter on the 14th day on the Passover month whether it fell on Sunday or not

-The Church of Rome celebrated Easter on a Sunday Day of resurrection

-He argued that the Church of Rome had great authority because it was founded by apostles peter and Paul .The traditions of the church goes back to the apostles.

-The apostles traditions was more powerful than that of the heretics who appealed to false traditions

-It was against heretics that he wrote his five volume book "against Heresies"

-In his 4th &5th volumes Irenaeus defended the Eucharist. He argued that the Eucharist became the body and the Blood of Christ, which gives the Human body the gift of God –eternal life

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He probably died around AD195.

TERTULLIAN (AD160-220)

He was born in Carthage N.Africa by pagan parents .He trained as a lawyer and was converted around AS192.

-He wrote in Greek and in Latin .He was the first to use the word trinity to describe God in three persons.

-He preached for Christians during the persecution. He encouraged the Christians to be faithful.

-He argued that the blood of Christians is the head of the church.

-That only Catholics have the right to use scripture because they are the only ones who belong to the scriptures.

-That only catholic priests should read and interpret the scriptures.

-He argued that Christians should not be soldier; civil servants or teachers and that they should avoid evil and should not marry even after death of one partner.

-He died around 220 AD

ORIGEN

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-He was born in Alexandria.
His parents were Christians.

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-He became the head of the school in Alexandria and soon became the greatest Christian scholar of the early church

-He was ordained presbyter in Palestine in AD230.

-He soon set another catechetical school in Caesarea. He suffered persecution and died in AS 254

-he was a great thinker argued that the soul exists before the body an argument which the church refused to accept.

-He taught that the death of Christ was a ransom price paid to the Devil, who thought that the death of Christ on the cross was a sign that he had defeated God.

-he argued that in the end be saved

-That Christ is of one substance with the Father .That he was eternally begotten of the father.

-That he was not created out that his soul was united to the divine word. He is close to saying that there are two Gods and that the father is the greater of the two.

-To him the H/S is not divine

-That ht genesis is story is a figurative expression of ideals-not actual events

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LESSON FIVE

a) EARLY CHISTIAN PERSECUTION

Why were the Christians persecuted?

Reasons

(1). The community grew faster than any other religious community known in the Roman History despite persecution.

In the 1st three centuries Christians were seriously persecuted but still the illegal movement was spreading

Initially it was the Jews who persecuted Christians for blasphemy. However later on the Romans saw Christianity as a threat because of its vast growth in membership.

They also started to persecute them.

2. The Christians considered themselves as a **separate** sect withdrawn from the Romans state. The state was threatened by the continued growth of the Christian fellowship in the whole empire in spite of persistent opposition and persecution from the Jews (hence the Romans started to persecute the Christians).

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3. The community condemned paganism.

The Christians refused to participate in pagans worship .They were thus seen as a threat to peace and prosperity that was enjoyed by the Romans .This because had influenced the Roman pagan gods. Misfortunes that occurred were thus blamed on the Christians

4. Political reasons

There was that Christianity might (overthrow) overturn not only the Romans culture but also the political leaders. The members recognized a God higher than the emperor .Thus did not recognize the authority of the Roman emperors

5. The revolution nature of Christianity

Due to its revolution nature, its un-compromising character, and its universality, Christianity was feared by the Romans authorities more than a.

6. Christian was seen as a secret association.

To avoid public attack or an opposition, Christianity held their meetings secretly without state permission.

They thus had defiled the law by forming a secret association

7. Lastly Christians were accused of sacrificing human flesh and blood claiming to share the body and blood of Jesus. They were thus accused of cannibalism.

-In brief the Christians ere accused of interfering with the National economy of the Roman state. They were also accused of disturbing both public and

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domestic peace as were as the distribution of sedition. The religion was directly opposed to the Roman Government and the ancient social system .Thus the members deserved death according to the Roman authorities.

b) NATURE OF THE ROMAN PERSECUTION OF CHRISTIANS

Until AD 64 there was no deliberate move by the Romans to persecute Christians and so all the persecutions by when were the Jews

The early Christian persecution by the Romans was started by emperor Nero in AD 64, what is referred to as the Neronian Persecution

Some parts of Rome were destroyed by fire in AD 64 . The Romans authorities blamed the Christians for the fire and persecution started. They were also accused of hating the Roman covenant. The Christian were killed by dogs others were crucified while others were set on fire. Peter and Paul were among those who died during Neronian persecution. Peter was crucified (upside down) hanged while Paul was beheaded. Nero committed suicide in AD 68 but Christian persecution persisted. But the emperors who followed him did not take persecution very seriously until AD 165 when in Asia minor 12 Christians were thrown to a den of beasts for refusing to abandon Christianity. However the beats refused to attack the Christians.

The disappointed crows ordered that their bishop Polycarp be martyred in instead. They lit fire which refused to burn him. Eventually they used the sword. Justin the Martyr was (also) slain after Bishop Polycarp.

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In AD177 a whole population of Christians was thrown to wild beasts for refusing to honour traditional gods. This was during the reign of Marcus Aurelius (161-185).

5. The period between 202-250 was relatively peaceful and the church in this period grew considerably and became like a state within the Roman state. However the Roman economy was sinking and once again this was blamed on the Christians who had rejected the Roman worship. In AD 250 Emperor Decius ordered a general sacrifice for Christians throughout the Roman Empire. Those who worshipped the idols obtained certificates. Those who did not have the certificates were persecuted. Many Christians in Egypt and in North Africa sacrificed to idols, others fled for their lives, while others bought the certificates. This period was a big blow to the church but the church was still growing.

In AD 258 all church leaders were to be executed and church's property confiscated. Christians were thus deprived of their property and their lives too. Cyprian of Carthage (Tunis in Tunisia) was martyred in this period. Those undergoing persecution believed that martyrdom (assured or) secured them a place in the future kingdom. Their relics of some of them were venerated while the dates of their deaths were celebrated annually. The Christians did not result to violence. They held that the devil was fighting the church of God. Many people died during Diocletian persecution.

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Some were crucified, other tossed in boiling oil, others shot with arrows, others were frozen to death-most of these have been canonized –became saints.

c) THE GREAT PERSECUTION

Around AD260 persecution was declared unlawful and the confiscated church property was returned and up to 300 AD Christians were employed in the army, courts and freely associated with others. For a while the church enjoyed a period of peace.

However the year 303 AD saw the beginning of a **great persecution** by then the Roman Empire fell into two provinces the **East and the West** with a ruler in each province. **Dialetian ruled the East while Maximian ruled the West.** The two emperors issued an edict (Public order or decree) that all scripture be handed to the Roman authorities for destruction and that no Christian meetings were to be held.

Another fire broke out in Rome and the Christians were once again persecuted in connection with it. Some of the clergy were arrested and forced to sacrifice to idols or be tortured.

In North Africa many Christians were set on fire. Others were drowned in the sea. As a result many North African Christians betrayed the church either by sacrificing to idols or by surrendering the Holy Scriptures for destruction.

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In Rome persecution was equally bad. Christians lost their jobs and many others became slaves .Church buildings were burned down and so were sacred books-This period saw the persecution of both the clergy and the laymen. **Corpses were denied burial**. Christians were chained and or crippled and later forced to sacrifice to idols. Tortured dead bodies were done the same. It was during Diocletian's rule that the church experienced the worst persecution in history. After Diocletian, Christian persecution was once again stopped by an addict. Christians were set free and persecuted suspended for some time.

LESSON SIX

A) CONSTANTINE AND THE FINAL VICTORY OF THE CHURCH

Constantine was the son of Constantius who (had) ruled the west up to AD305. When Constantine took over from his Father (the following year) He set free all the Christians .He ordered that church property be returned to the church. As a result of the freedom given to the Christians, Constantine made many enemies especially from the East.

In AD 312 he attacked and killed the Eastern ruler Maxintius. His victory was divine. It is argued that Constantine had divine inspiration to put the sign of the cross on the soldiers shields, which he did. Constantine eventually won the battle by the protection of God. He later conquered most of his political enemies in the East and by AD 324 Constantine was the sole ruler of the entire Roman Empire He established his capital in the city of Constantinople

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East which he dedicated to the church (later became the centre of the church in the East)

In AD 313 the Edict of Milan finally gave legal recognition to Christianity.
The era of Christians persecution was finally over.

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B) THE CONTRIBUTION OF CONSTANTINE TO THE CHURCH

POSITIVE

1. The Edict of Milan brought to an end the era of Christian persecution. It brought very close relationships, between the church and the state which lasted for about 1500 years.
2. Christianity gained final victory. Christians were able to attend church services freely. The church developed her mission. Christianity became the official religion of the Romans
3. (Great) churches were built .Constantine himself constructed two churches in honor of Christians Martyrs.

Sacraments were celebrated without any problems.

4. More Bible were printed & circulated & read
5. General councils of Bishops were held to settle religion disputes. e.g the council of Nicaea
6. Sunday was officially declared the day of Christian worship as well as public holiday.
7. (Under Christian influence) Marriage became more permanent and concubine was abolished.
8. infanticide and abortion which had been frequent practices were made criminal offences.
9. Hospitals and small charitable groups were founded.
10. Slavery and forced labour were condemned
11. Christianity became a unifying factor in the Roman Empire.

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C) NEGATIVE

1. The church was flooded with a large number of Christians some of whom were nominal Christians.
2. The office of the Bishops became very wealthy and politically influential and later corrupt.
3. The church started to run the state –i.e. it was seen as one and the same.

Q3. Discuss the contribution of the Constantine to the growth of the church

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LESSON SEVEN

HERESIES & EARLY CHURCH COUCILS

1 The First Council of Nicaea and Arianism (325)

Arianism or Arian controversy or heresy comes from a scholar from (the) Alexandria school (N. Africa) named ARIUS. Arius argued that Christ was a created being and hence not same as God.

That is he was not of the same substance or equal with the Father. -That he was not eternal; since he is a son who had a beginning unlike the Father.

-That he was not fully God since he was lower than Him (God).He could therefore not have been one with the Father but in between man and God.

-That since he was created there was a time when he was not, thus he is not eternal.

-That he was God's first creation, the logos or wisdom and that through him everything else was created.

-Arianism threatened the unity of the church and also the unity of the Roman state. Constantine thus summoned all the Bishops to a meeting in Nicaea (Asia minor) in AD 325.This was the 1st great council of the church. The aim was to end the Arian controversy which had more or less divided the church into East and West.

-Athanasius showed the consequences of Arianism. That it denied incarnation, and revelation .Therefore redemption would have been impossible.

-That worship of Christ is idolatry if he was created.

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. Athanasius insisted that Christ is of the same substance with the Father
.That he is fully God and fully man, and that he is truly divine and truly human.

.Finally the Nicene Creed was formulated during the council of Nicaea.

.The creed concluded that Christ was 'begotten from the Father and not made and of the 'same substance' with the Father 'truly God and Truly Man'

However the Nicene creed was not accepted by the whole church.

.Arius and his supporters were exiled by the church.

-Arius died in AD 328.

He made the church think deeply about her doctrines.

2 The First Council of Constantinople (381) and Trinitarian Controversy

Constantinople is an ancient city **in modern-day Turkey. It is now** known as **Istanbul**

The second general council of the Church was called by emperor Theodosius in Constantinople in 381 AD. The council dealt with the identity of the **Holy Spirit**. The Trinitarian controversy did not give (accord) the Holy Spirit divine recognition or divine status.

-The council emphasized that each of the **three persons** of the trinity **had distinctive forms of existence yet related**.

-That the **son is generated** by the father and that the spirit proceeds from the father **through the son**.

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-That the **Father is the source of divine activities**; the son carries them out and the Holy Spirit completes the work.

-The doctrine of the Trinity was finally shaped in the 1st council of Constantinople. It affirmed that the Holy Spirit was **equal with the Father and the son** and that the **three were one**. The Trinitarian controversy had been solved.

3. The council of Ephesus-431

The council dealt with the **nature of Christ**. This council was called by emperors **Theodosius 11** of the East and **Valentinian 111** of the West.

-The council dealt with **Apollinarianism and Nestorianism** regarding Christological controversy. I.e the nature of Christ

-Apollinarianism emphasized the **perfect and complete divinity** of **Christ**. That it was the totality of Christ which was divine and not part of Him.

That salvation was possible because of his **divine nature**. The human nature was thus **replaced or swallowed by the divine** nature.

-The **logos** united with the flesh in a special way and could not be **human** otherwise he could have **been a sinner** –His humanity changed.

-The **womb of Mary was only a passive way**. It did not change this **divine nature**. Although Christ took human flesh, His nature was **purely divine**.

-The council also dealt with Nestorianism from Nestorius. He emphasized that the **two natures of Christ existed distinctively side by side** and should not be confused.

-That Mary could not have **given birth to God**. In any case God could not have been born.

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- So she gave birth to the man Jesus, after birth the logos united himself with Jesus.
- The council of Ephesus maintained the **two nature of Christ** in one substance.
- Nestorianism continued to exist strongly in Persia and later spread to Asia and China.
- Nestorius was exiled by the emperor Theodosius II.
- The council concluded that the **logos** took human nature and became Jesus Christ. The **theory of incarnation** was thus developed more clearly in the council of Ephesus and was added to the Nicean creed.

4 Eutychianism and the Council of Chalcedon-451 AD

Eutychianism is derived from a theologian of Constantinople named **Eutyches**. His view is that the **union of human and divine** resulted in the human being **fully swallowed up by the divine**. Christ was thus **truly divine but not truly human**

- The views of the western church which were contained in a letter by Pope Leo I called the 'Tome of Leo' were that **in Christ there was no manhood without true divinity no was there divinity without man hood.**
- This position was adopted in the council of Chalcedon, the 4th ecumenical council.
- The council condemned Eutychianism and came up with the Chalcedonian formula or definition of faith with regard to the person of Christ.
- The Chalcedonian formula or creed taught that men should confess **one and the same Son, the Lord Jesus Christ**

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- That he is true God and true man with a reasonable soul and body. -
- That he is one substance with the Father according to his Godhead and co-substantial with man according to his manhood.
- That he was begotten before all ages according to the Godhead
- That for our salvation he was born of the Virgin Mary the God bearer according to his manhood.
- The council thus emphasized the unchangeable, indivisible and inseparable divine and human nature of Christ.
- However the Eastern Church was not satisfied with the formula .Thus the East west conflict resulted.

5. Monophysitism and the Second Council of Constantinople (553)

The Chalcedonian council did not settle the issue about the nature of Christ completely. The Eastern Church maintained that Christ's human nature was swallowed completely by his divinity. This was the monophysite position that Christ was Divine. The western church on the other hand maintained the two indivisible natures of Christ i.e divine and human.

- This controversy as a result led to the first serious East –west schism (division).
- The monophysite (Church) position was adopted by the church in Egypt, Ethiopia and later in Syria.
- The monophysites argued that the chalcedonian creed was idolatrous since it presented two faces of the same Christ.
- They argued that two natures implied two persons-hence idols

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-They said that Christ had only the divine nature which transformed the human nature into divine reality.

Attempts to bring together the East and the west proved very difficult not even **excommunication or persecution** could bring the church together once again.

-The 2nd council of Constantinople was thus called to reconcile the two parties.

-The council argued that Christ had **two natures in one person**. This problem led to the sixth ecumenical council, **Constantinople III**

6 The Monothelite Controversy and the Third Council of Constantinople (680-681)

The Monothelite controversy argued that Christ had **one will** since he had **only one nature**. This is the divine will.

-However the position of the council was that **Christ had two wills; divine and human**. But the divine will **dominated** worked through the human will.

-This council once again failed to resolve the controversy. As a result the **Eastern Church** called its own council to discuss the western wing. The council passed that the Bishop of Constantine shall enjoy equal privilege with that of **Rome**.

-It **permitted marriage of deacons** and **presbyters**, and condemned the Roman prohibition of such marriages.

-It condemned the Roman custom of fasting (on Sundays) in lent. (The Greek Church still maintains these practices)

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7 Iconoclastic Controversy and the Second Council of Nicaea (787)

The council dealt with the use of **Icon religious purposes** referred to as Iconclasticism. The church in the East condemned the use of images of saints, church fathers, Christ, Joseph and Mary among others as a form of paganism.

-The destruction of icons was started by Emperor Leo the 3rd around 725 AD. This was followed by destruction of an **image of Christ . consequently a riot followed.**

-The council was called to the discuss the use of Icons. It declared that icons were a useful means of worship which **attracted both Christians and non Christians**

-They were symbols (that) which **served to mediate invisible divinity.**

-The use of Icons in worship was thus officially accepted in this council.

However the division between East and West was never solved by these councils .This led to great schism.

LESSON EIGHT

THE GREAT SCHISM (1ST MAJOR SPLIT THAT RESULTED TO THE ROMAN &THE ORTHODOX CHURCHES)

1. Reasons; Heresies saw increased tension and rivalry between the church of the west and that of the East. Most of the heresies were from the Eastern Church . Attempts to solve some of the heresies led to deeper hostilities between East & West.

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2 Domination - The church in the west (Rome) claimed the right to determine the faith of the church in most of the church councils.

3. Patriarchy- By the year 518 the Eastern Church had 4 patriarchs viz at Constantinople, Jerusalem, Antioch and Alexandria. The western had its patriarch in Rome .The five rules the church –they occasionally conflicted.

4. Through out the 6th and the 7th centuries, attempts to unite the church were not successful.

This period is described as the period of **watery unions**. The council of Lateran conveyed in 649 to reconcile the East and the west ended in more tension.

5 The year 1054 saw the eastern patriarch Michael cerularius violently quarreling with Pope Leo ix. The pope in a Bull (authoritative papal document which must be obeyed) excommunicated the patriarch Michael and his supporters burned the bull.

6. Authority-The East-west relationship become worse when the **western patriarch** claimed authority above the **Eastern patriarchs** .He claimed to be the **universal head and ruler of the Christian** church.

-However the **Eastern patriarchs did not accord him** any higher authority above them. Hatred between East and west increased.

7. Crusades-Between the 11th and the 13th centuries the church fought holy wars called **crusades** to recapture the holy lands from the Muslims. These

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were the lands associated with the birth, life, suffering, death and resurrection of Christ.

-Following the crusades the Eastern Church sought assistance from the west but with no positive results. Consequently the Eastern Church awakened against the Moslems enemies. From this time onwards bitterness between east and west was almost permanent.

8 Refusal to see the pope as the vicar. The Eastern Church categorically refused to recognize the pope of Rome as **the Vicar of Christ**; having the right to govern the entire Christian church consequently all efforts to unify the church failed.

-By the end of the 14th century, the church finally split into East and west or the orthodox and the Roman Catholic with their patriarchs in Constantinople, and Rome respectively. The west adopted Latin while the

East adopted Greek as official languages. The great schism had occurred

LESSON TEN

THE RISE OF SCHOLASTICISM

The most striking feature of Christianity towards the end of the medieval period was intensive intellectual awakening. Theological problems presented in the Gospel (N.T) became a major subjects of study, influenced by both Plato and Aristotle, this period developed some of the great philosophers who were to shape theology. For example Anselm of N Africa & Thomas Aquinas. The starting point of much of the intellectual revival of the middle ages was Plato,s theory of ideas. What is referred to as idealism.

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He argued that the things we see or experience are nothing other than reflections or **shadow of the real world which we cannot experience.**

Scholasticism was an attempt to combine in one logical system all available knowledge especially **theology and philosophy.**

The founders of scholasticism (school) were Albertus Magnus and his student Thomas Aquinas (both Italians) and Dominican Friars)

Scholasticism arose from the schools of the 12th century and the students were known **as school men.** Paris was the centre of scholastic theology whose aim was to try to reconcile **religion and reason.** Matters of **the faith** were subjected to the tools of reason to ascertain their relationships.

Scholasticism produced two important schools of thought viz **Realism** and **nominalism.** The realists argued that **things are what they are** and they exist in **depended of the mind** of **the thinker** .The reality such as men, trinity, God etc exist in itself with or without the mind.

On the other hand the **nominalists** maintained that things are just **ideas** and therefore cannot be known **with certainty what** we knew **are not the things themselves** but rather **ideas about them.** Therefore reality cannot be perceived. Such argument were later advanced by philosophy of the church.

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ST ANSELM OF AOSTA (1033-1109)

An Italian by birth, Anselm was the first original thinker in the **west in the medieval period** .He attempted to show that **faith** could be approved by **reason**. He argued that to doubt the existence is to **prove it** for we cannot **doubt the** existence of that which does **not exist** .Therefore to doubt the existence of God is simply to affirm that he exists. He developed the argument that "**God is that than which nothing greater can be conceived to exist**" He says that the idea of a **perfect being** (necessitates the idea of a being which is existing (real) this is so because **a being which lacks existence would not be conceived as perfect.**

Anselm is honoured for his contribution To the **incarnation** (the double nature of Jesus Christ).The general view by then was that the purpose of the incarnation was that the **devil might not seize** the son of God thinking of him to be **only a man** . He says that God could not have disregarded **man's sin without compromising his moral nature**. To maintain his moral order therefore there was need for a **satisfactory sacrifice** equal to the offence or else man would have remained **a sinner for ever** and consequently frustrate the **intention of the creator**.

Wile its man who must compensate (suffer) for his sin, **only God could make the compensation satisfactory** .It is for this reason that **God became incarnate** in man so as to make man's redemption possible.

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ST.THOMAS AQUINAS (1225-1274)

Thomas and his teacher Albert Magnus were the first scholars to demonstrate that theology cannot be understood completely without three things viz **reason, faith** and **revelation** .According to Thomas the channels of revelation are **the Bible**, and **the church** while that of reason is **philosophy**. He said that matters of the trinity **incarnation, original sin**, and the **resurrection** are matters of faith and revelation and not reason:-

1. God. Thomas is famous for his five ways to prove the existence of God

a. The motion Argument: That things are of two categories, the moved and movers .However all of them are moved the **unmoved mover.-God**

b. The causal argument:-That is God is uncaused cause which causes everything else. Otherwise there would be endless cause and effects.

c. The necessary being: That there are necessary and contingent beings .However the contingent beings depend on a necessary being for their existence .This necessary being is God.

d. Ultimate purpose: Everything has a purpose and God is the ultimate giver of all purposes. He gives everything else its meaning and purpose.

e.Ultimate perfection: Every being tries to be perfect but none has ever attained perfection or the highest level of goodness which is God.

2 . Man: He says that God created the whole world out of his Divine love and set Man free to do his will However man sinned and corrupted the world. Since the fall man seeks the highest good which he lost .He says that man's

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restoration is possible only through the free and un merited Grace of God; but not by man himself.

Unlike Anselm he believes that God could have as well saved man without having necessarily to sacrifice Jesus Christ .However man could not have saved himself and this is why Christ had to participate .The redemption enables Gods grace and gives the power to fulfill his call.

3. Sacraments :He says that grace has its define channels ,the sacraments i.e. Baptism extreme unction (anointing the dead body)confirmation ,Eucharist, Penance, ordination and Matrimony.

-All of them were instated by Christ directly or through his apostles and convey God's grace to man (through Jesus)

-That every sacrament has two elements i.e. material (water, wine, bread, oil) and a formula conveying its sacred use.(e.g. I Baptist u in the name of the Father ,the Son and the Holy Spirit)

4 Eucharist; On Eucharist he argues that while accidents of the bread and wine (shape, taste, colour, size, smell etc) remain unchanged, the substance is transformed by his power of God into Jesus Christ. He developed the view that the whole body in either element

5 The Lords supper; He says the lords supper is a confirmation of the incarnation and the passion (suffering).To the recipient ,it is the source of spiritual up building and the evidence of his union with Christ,.

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6 Penance ; Penance according to him involves contribution (confession – satisfaction an absolution

-That an absolute confersion must be made to the priest

-He advocated for temporal penalties as a consequences of sin. These are the fruits of repentance and could be remitted through indulgences

7. Purgatory: He argued that after death the wicked will pass to hell which is endless and were there is no release .However those who have obtained grace through the sacraments go at once to heaven. While those who have imperfectly availed themselves to the grace of God must undergo purification in purgatory.

8. Church : He claimed that the church is one .That the good of one member is shared by the others and so is suffering.

That the visible church requires a visible head, the pope and to be subject to him is necessary for salvation. Thomas Aquinas (greatly) shaped the doctrine of he church to a great extent. Most of whatever he taught is still the official teaching of the Roman Catholic Church even today.

-Contribution: sincere sorrow for Sins committed

-Absolution: Declaration by the priest that one is forgiven

EXPANSION THROUGH THE CRUSADES

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1. The crusades were the Holy wars organized by **Christians** between 11th and **14th centuries** to recover the Holy land or holy places from the **Moslems**.

These were sited in Palestine and its environment which were connected with the life passion and resurrection of Jesus Christ. e.g. Galilee, Jerusalem, Nazareth, Bethlehem etc-The Mohammedans also visited many sites in Palestine .

2. In the **11th century** the **Seljuks**, a tribe from Turkistan, -Turkey moved westwards from Baghdad and captured **Jerusalem**.(from their fellow Muslims)-it should be noted that the Seljuk Turks were a fierce **Moslems race**.

-The first crusade resulted from an appeal of the Eastern Emperor **Michael vii** (1067-1078) to Pope **Gregory vii** to fight the Muslims. However this did not materialize until the time of Pope Urban II

They then invaded **Asia Minor** (which was part of the **Byzantine** Empire and captured 1\2 of the empire in AD 1071. (Eastern Roman Empire)This made it difficult for the Christians to visit the holy places especially Jerusalem.

3. The pope (Gregory) pronounced the first crusade in a synod held in Clermont in France around 1095. He called for all Christians to participate in indulgences to the participants.

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-Indulgences is the pardon for temporal punishment for sins committed. Plenary indulgence means full remission or forgiveness of all temporal punishment.

-Preachers such as **Peter the Hermit** traveled all over Western Europe convincing Christians to participate in the crusades.

-This resulted to the **first crusades** in **1096** in which an army left France to **Constantinople**.

-They captured **Nicaea and Iconium** in 1097, **Antioch** in 1098 and **Jerusalem** in 1099.

-However the Mohamedans recaptured **Jerusalem** in **1144**.

As a result **Bernard of Clairvaux** organized the second crusade which involved both **France and Germany**. Nonetheless this crusade was a failure and by **1178** the Moslems occupied as far as **Egypt** as well as **Northern, Eastern and Southern** part of **Roman emperor**.

-The 3rd crusade which was organized by the **Roman Emperor Fredrick Babarosa**, King Philip Augustus of France and king Richard of England was also a failure. As a result Jerusalem remained in the hands of the Moslems until **1202** when **the 4th** crusade was launched.

-This crusade recaptured **Egypt, Jerusalem , Nazareth and Bethlehem** remained under Moslems until **1299** when emperor **Fredrick** of Germany gained them for the Christians by a treaty.

-However they were again lost to the Moslems.

It should be noted that the war between Moslems & Jews over such lands \places is an old one.

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The result of the crusades

1. Military monastic orders

The crusades were not organized to capture and protect the Holy land but were also wedged against Islam, pagans and heretics etc.

The chief participants were France German and England.Rome.

-However the greatest individual group was that of the military orders.

Such orders were (a) the knights of the sword

(b)The hospitallers

(c)The templers

(d)Teutonic knights.

The members regarded themselves as warriors who had dedicated their lives and arms to the service of Jesus Christ.

They took monastic vows of poverty, chastity and obedience.

-Their role was to fight for and defend the Holy places protect pilgrims &cared for the sick.

2. The crusades severed the Christian attitude towards war. It was argued that wars could be just and holy if they are willed by God.

3. The crusades failed in that they did not put the Holy places permanently into the possession of the Christians.

4. They weakened the relationship between the East and the West due to accusations and counter accusations.

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5. The crusades permanently embittered relations between Christians and Muslims which has continued to the present.
6. The wars resulted to (geographical) spread of Christianity to central and Far East.
7. They stimulated (a lot of) commerce in the Roman world.
8. They opened people into others civilization which was followed by intellectuals awakening.

LESSON NINE

MEDIEVAL HERETICS AND THE INQUISITION

- The 12th and 13th centuries was a period of great **intellectual activities**. The period is also characterized by the zeal to reform the church and the papal shaken by heretics in this period than ever before.
- As a result the church organized **a special commission called inquisition** to discover and punish heretics.-
- Some of the popular movement which led the inquisition included the **Cathari** or **Albegenses** and the Waldenses.

CATHARI (OR ALBEGENSES)

The Cathari meaning pure also called Albegenses in France broke from the Catholic Church in the **12th century**.

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- The movement then spread in Spain, France and Italy.
- By 1200 the movement had almost dominated the church. They taught that Satan and Jesus were both Sons of God.
- However Satan rebelled and Jesus became the redeemer.
- .Believed in material world, which is evil and spiritual world- good.
- .That the church of Rome was evil and the church of Jesus is good.
- .They rejected sacraments and church orders.
- .Believed that flesh is evil hence Christ had no flesh.
- .That he had no real body and hence could not have died a real death.
- .Hence his crucifixion, resurrection and ascension were not real.
- .they condemned marriage and ownership of prosperity.
- .They rejected the O.T and adopted the NT
- .Their clergy were called 'the perfect'
- .They had simple masses, celebrated the Lords supper once a month
(protestant xtianity)
- .They rejected crucifixes and other icons

THE WALDENCES

- The Waldences were founded by **Peter Waldo** who had given his property to the poor and taken to ascetic life.
- .The men went around preaching and were consequently excommunicated by Pope Licius III in 1184
 - .They taught that the Church of Rome was not the head of the Catholic Church- and .That lay men and women could preach.
 - .They rejected masses for the dead.

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.Argued that grace cannot come from graceless men, and that all Goodman are priest's sacrament depended on the merit of the celebrant (not on the sacrament).

That good man can also give valid absolution just as the pope

. They denied \condemned purgatory, indulgences, confersion, penance, use of relied, crusades, oathing.

.The poor men of Lyons like the Cathari, spread to Spain, Italy, Germany, France and Switzerland

.By 1250 Pope Gregory xi instructed that all heretics be persecuted .As many as 150 were buried and others imprisoned.

.The remnants later joined the reformations.

THE INQUISITION

Efforts to convert medieval peacefully failed.

-The church then resulted to crusades. Many of them were crushed and their property taken by the church.

-The church in 1229 forbid the possession of the scriptures by the laity. Heretics were to be executed by fire. This led to establishment of a special commission of the Dominican order to persecute heretics –This is referred to as **the inquisition**.

-The inquisition \commission derived its authority from the pope who by then was Innocent III who was one of the most powerful.

-The inquisitors condemned heretics and confiscated their property.

-Inquisitors were like a hit squad.

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- They arrested, cross examined tortured, imprisoned and persecuted heretics on behalf of the church papacy.
- The inquisition established itself firmly in France, Italy, Germany and England.
- By 15th century, it had almost silenced the heretics but did not solve the questions that were being raised by the heretics. Such questions and much more led to the reformation sometimes later.

THE PAPACY FROM IN THE MEDIEVAL TIME (1300-1517)

1. The council of Constance

In the middle ages, Pope carried the papacy to its highest authority. The Bishop of Rome was the most powerful man in the church. He represented Peter the man chosen by Jesus himself to run the church. Every creature had therefore be the subject to the Roman pope declared **Pope Boniface**

viii

Towards the close of the period, the demand for an **Italian pope increased**. Most of the popes before then were **French**. The demand for an Italian pope saw **almost another great schism**. After the death of pope **Gregory xi** around 1378 an Italian pope **Urban vi** was elected. However the French cardinals declared the his election null and void went ahead to elect a French pope, **Clement vi**. As a result the church was under two popes one at **Rome (Italian)** and the other at **Avignon (French)** in France claimed to rule the church simultaneously.

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Efforts to end the schism was realized in the council of Constance in 1414. The two popes were forced to resign and a supreme pope **Martin V** was elected. However the power of the pope grew even more and was a major factor for the reformation

2. The Black Death;

Between 1348-1350, Europe faced a devastating plague known as "the black death". About 1/3 of the population were feared dead. People were as a result faced with many social-economic hardships.

Above all they were obsessed with the **ideas of death** and **the last judgment**.

-Skeletons of people were drawn on walls and along streets to signify the epidemic People were indeed very scared.

-As a result **prayers for the dead** were encouraged by the church but with no Biblical evidence for such prayers

-The church re-defined **purgatory, hell** and **heaven** .It was said that the un baptized and all Christians who died in **mortal sin** (deadly sin) un repented, are condemned to hell while those who die completely holy would go directly to **heaven**. However those who died having committed **venial sins** must suffer in purgatory, where there is no pain but the deprivation of God's presence. This could be paid through what the church called **penance**.

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3. Penance;

This was an **act of discipline** imposed by the church as an **outward expression of sorrow** by offender or sinners. It later came to include **payments** by **cash** or **kind** to the church, or to the poor, or a pilgrimage. However the church preferred the payment of money. This later became the sale of **indulgences**

4 Indulgences; There developed a strong believe that doing **penance** on earth would minimize if not wipe out the pains to be suffering by a sinner in purgatory. The pope claimed to have the **power to remit** not only **earthly penance** but also pains of purgatory. This claim was based on the doctrine of the **treasure of merit**. The argument was that the prayers and merits of the saints could obtain salvation for the other Christians. It was also argued that the **pope holds the key to this treasure**. Both arguments were developed during the reign of the **rival popes who desperately looked for money to support the papacy**. This resulted to the **selling of indulgence** or **pardons** purporting to free those who paid them from some or all of the pains in **purgatory**. This practice was condemned strongly by the reformers

5. Eucharistic sacrifice

There is little evidence in the Bible that the death of Jesus Christ was a sacrifice and that the Eucharist is a memorial of it. This belief differed considerably from the Jewish understanding and practice of sacrifice. **The church taught that in the Eucharist the body and blood of Christ are perfected**

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under the form of bread and wine .This doctrine was also challenged by the reformers

6 Masses of the dead

St Thomas is said to have argued that prayer and masses offered for the souls in purgatory would be helpful, however it was not until the middle of the 14th century that the cult of masses for the dead arose.

The black death made people more concerned with masses for the dead . Rich men left a lot of money with the church so that masses could be said for the cleansing of their souls. Many charity chapels were built on top of people tombs and priests stationed there to say daily masses for the dead who had paid money .This practice was condemned by the reformers.

THE RENAISSANCE

-By the end the 14th century, the renaissance, which was to change the Medieval period into the modern period was already advanced in **Italy**.

During this period, Italian cities enjoyed comparative peace and affluence (wealth). Men began to re-visit literally work or reading and academics applying new knowledge to religion. The period of the renaissance falls between 1450 and 1527, just before the reformation.

-The term renaissance is used to describe an attitude towards life which valued present (earth) more than future(heaven), Immortality of fame more than immortality of the soul ; the delights of the flesh more than asceticism;

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success more than justice; individual and intellectual freedom more than authority and classical humanism; concerning Human needs not religious; ancient Greek & Roman literature more than Christianity literature.

-With renaissance came **secularism**, where Man's place in the universe was being re-defined. He (man) became autonomous, self-sufficient. He saw no need for God. Man had become the moulder of his own destiny.

-The Renaissance man was interested in the development of the body as well as the mind.

-The period of the renaissance developed prominent artists, sculptors, painters, architects, poets, scientists, mathematicians and engineers/inventors i.e. high class scholars such as Michelangelo, Leonardo da Vinci and Machiavelli among others.

It was a period of great learning and thinking or reasoning. The renaissance idea was to make man as a complete human being as possible without religion if possible.

-During the Renaissance period, secularism (separation between religion and secular) was manifested in the Papacy. Only a few popes were distinguished for their spirituality. Popes were corrupt, and scandalous where some had illegitimate children. (Alexander VI) Others like Pope Sixtus II loved war and had their own troops, others e.g. Pope Leo X is said to have spent more money and time on gambling, hunting and games. He is quoted to have said "The papacy is ours, let us enjoy it". He was the pope when Martin Luther posted his ninety five theses of Wittenberg.

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-In the renaissance period, the church was drawn into involvement in capitalistic dealings. She started operating banking, Business, borrowing and lending out loan for profits

-The period saw the growth of fidelism i.e. faith without rational support.

Some doctrines e.g. the trinity and immortality of the soul were questioned.

The thinkers said that the trinity is philosophically un-provable. On immortality they argued that no soul can survive dissociated from the body.

-Theological arguments were subjected to historical criticism .This saw the rise of the historical critical method of studying the Bible.

-The period saw humanism which discounted the uniqueness of the Christian religion and viewed it equal to other world religious. Especially Judaism &Islam.

-The period of the renaissance saw a great revival of mysticism and more concern with death .The Humanists maintained that he who had clean hands and pure heart needed not worry about death and after life. This belief saw the origin of a revival movement called **the friends of God** who originated in **Holland** early in the **14th century** .The society was somehow monastic but members were (very) free.

Their supreme vow was the imitation of Christ .ie walking in the steps of the Saviour and sharing with him the cup of his passion rather than upon theological formulations.

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The renaissance was **rediscovering a Christian truth** which had been neglected by insisting on the value of the individual

The period also saw the **painting of biblical stories on church walls** and the **acting of such stories in public places**. Many traditional **Christian carols date back to this period**.

The renaissance saw the rise and development of individualistic worship in the western church. The Eucharist / Lord's supper was never again to be celebrated by the **whole congregation** as it were. Priests were found celebrating the mass in privacy. The Holy Communion (Eucharist) was to be celebrated only by a few. The period of the renaissance had prepared the reformation which seemed inevitable.

THE REFORMATION

THE EARLY REFORMERS (JOHN WHYCLIFF)

Conditions within the medieval church led to attempts to reform the church from within. A notable example is **John Wycliff** an oxford scholar and Roman catholic priest of a scholar until his death .He condemned the accumulation of property by the church and advocated for its confiscation .He maintained that the authority of the pope was not founded on scripture .He condemned the worship of saints ,veneration of relics ,the belief in purgatory, pilgrimage and the practice of confession (He attacked Monasticism .He denied that priests alone could perform the miracle of bringing Christ himself down to the alter in the form of bread and wine) He also denied that the

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substance of the bread and wine changed into the body and blood of Jesus Christ during consecration –(Eucharistic sacrament)

He took **the Bible** as the only standard measure of Christian action .He believed that it should be **read by all** the Christians. He started the first English translation of the Bible from the **Latin translation** .This was to become the basis for other (English) translations

He organized a society of poor priests which he later (nicknamed Lollards) and sent them to preach in the villages and towns in England .each of the preachers carried with them a copy of the **Wycliff Bible** which had been completed in 1378.Christians were able to read the bible in English for the first time.

Wycliff was condemned as a heretic and when he died from a stroke his enemies declared that it was God's punishment for his misdeeds .Forty four years later his body was dug up from the grave and burnt and the ashes were thrown into a river.

His followers (the lollards) were persecuted in 1400 by King Henry iv however the movement continued as an underground movement in England .The Lollards prepared the English men to receive the reformation.

Wycliffe doctrines influenced John Huss of Bohemia, (part of Czechoslovakia) a preacher and a university professor. He began to preach to the people in their own Bohemian language instead of the official language. He led a great movement against the evils of the church which had been pointed out by Wycliff. He was condemned as a heretic and summoned to a great council

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of the church at Constance in Switzerland in 1415. He refused to submit to the authority of the council and was imprisoned and later burnt alive for heresy. His followers grew in large numbers to become the Moravians movement.

Another early reformer was Dante Alighieri. He also reacted against the authority of the pope. He argue that the pope could not claim superiority over the emperor because the two derived their authority from God.

Other reformers, went further to teach that both the papal and the royal powers are based on the people. It's by the people and for the people that the rulers in the church and the secular state reappointed.

They argued that the only final authority is the New Testament (not the whole Bible) That all clergy are equal and neither the Bishop nor the pope has spiritual authority over those below him.

They went further to claim that Peter was equal to the other apostles and that there is no New Testament evidence that he was ever in Rome.

That no individual (pope) has authority to define Christian truth as contained in the New Testament. This can only be done by a General council which is a representative of the whole Christian believers.

This led to the formation of the councilor movement which attempted to end the great schisms. It claimed authority over all people including the popes, Urban vi and Clement vi were forced to resign and pope Martin v elected (1417-1431), the new pope restored the papal authority .The efforts of the

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conciliar movement to reform the church had completely failed and the pope was once again above all men. The reformation was therefore inevitable.

THE GREAT REFORMATION (GENERAL CAUSES) 16TH-17TH CENTUARY.

The whole complex religious phenomenon in the western church in the 16th and 17th centaury, popularly known as the Reformation and constitute one of the most important event in the history of the church until after the reformation. The Catholic Church was the most powerful institution at that time.

1. Corruption in the church

Popes were elected through corrupt means others admitted illegitimate children born to them after their ordinations

2 Bishops were more like temporal rulers than servants of God. They were like political rulers who had no much time for their spiritual duties

3. The bad effects of enforcement clerical celibacy and monasticism .These had led to clerical concubinage.

4. The church acquired a lot of wealth which clergy misappropriated .There were dubious methods of raising funds such as the selling of indulgence and papal taxes in the name of putting up churches. Non payment of church dues meant excommunication; the reformers they insisted that finances of the church be audited.

5. **Failure of the church** –papacy –to reform. The papacy and the clergy were becoming increasingly unpopular due to their evil deeds and were stubborn to amend their ways. They had suppressed the reformers for many years therefore started as purely a religious movement within the western church. Luther gave new ideas to

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the doctrine of justification by faith. By this doctrine, people found freedom from the restless sense of sin.

6. **The Renaissance:** this was a period of great learning and questioning of certain practiced of the church. The New Testament had been printed (1516) and scholars were able to read the text. The abuses of the church were clearly expressed by the scholars. Some of the church practices were found to be un-scriptural. Hence protests

7. **The translation of the Bible;** after the Bible was translated into common languages e.g. English by Wycliffe –A Roman catholic Priest till his death, many people were able to read it. Individuals felt competent to read the Bible for themselves the true doctrines. Many people came to differ with many of the church doctrines. The reformation was an attempt to correct such evils.-